Q+A

HITTING IT OUT OF THE PARK

Ace batter ***Shafali Verma****'s winning performance in the Women's Cricket World Cup has put her back in the spotlight*



Photograph: GETTY IMAGES

Q. Prior to the semi-final call up you weren't in the ODI national team for nearly a year. How did you cope with that?

It was the saddest moment for me. The first message of support came from my backers JSW Sports who said, "We are with you". I kept going, accepted things, and felt it was the best time to work on myself. I think the Almighty noticed all my hard work and sent me to the team.

Q. It's not easy for a 21-year-old to come in the do-or-die stages of the tournament and deliver the goods. What was going through your mind?

I was very happy to get the call but it was a crucial stage so I was feeling the pressure to perform in the semis. I went with a positive mindset and told myself that this is the time to show what Shafali Verma is.

Q. The World Cup victory is a turning point for Indian women's cricket. Do you sense a shift in the tide?

We wanted that one WC to come for things to start going. Hopefully, we won't be judged now and will get a standing of our own. There's pressure too with the T20 World Cup next year.

Q. You are everywhere. How much are you enjoying the spotlight and being a role model to girls and young women?

I am enjoying it a lot. I love wearing different clothes and looking good. I always think of how to motivate youngsters like me. I try and give my best to the game. I want to encourage parents to let their kids go out and hopefully after the World Cup win all girls will get the opportunity to step out, pursue their passion and shine.

—with Suhani Singh